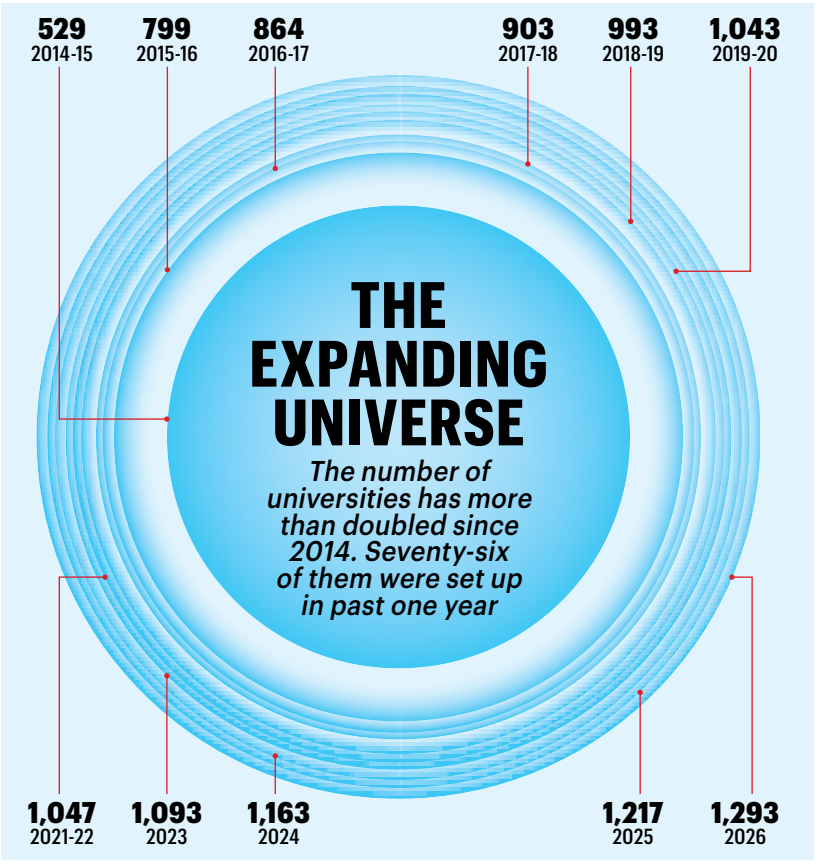
models of institutional management. It has also made independent assessment more necessary. The label 'private' does not by itself denote either excellence or inadequacy, just as the label 'public' does not guarantee quality. Institutions within both categories vary widely in faculty strength, research culture, infrastructure, affordability, governance and graduate outcomes. For families navigating hundreds of universities and thousands of courses, the central question is no longer about a recognised degree, but equally its educational value. The INDIA TODAY Best University Survey makes that assessment easier.

The expansion of institutions has been accompanied by a substantial increase in participation. The Gross Enrolment Ratio for the 18-23 age group rose from 23.7 per cent in 2014-15 to 30 per cent in 2023-24. The National Education Policy 2020 aims to raise it to 50 per cent by 2035. Female GER, at 31.2 per cent, has exceeded male GER for seven consecutive years, an indication that access for women has improved.

Enrolment, however, is only one part of the story. It records who enters the system, but not whether students find competent teachers, whether classes and examinations are held on time, whether they acquire the skills their courses promise, or whether financial, academic and social pressures force them to leave without completing their degrees.

Some of these concerns are reflected in the anger visible in the protests. They explain why a survey must evaluate more than reputation. A famous name may open doors, but it cannot compensate indefinitely for inadequate teaching, poor student support, obsolete curricula or unreliable examinations. Conversely, a less celebrated university may be improving quickly, building strong departments or producing better outcomes in a discipline.



THE UNIVERSITY ECOSYSTEM

TYPE OF UNIVERSITY	TOTAL NUMBER
CENTRAL UNIVERSITIES	57
STATE UNIVERSITIES	521
DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITIES	157
PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES	558
TOTAL	1,293

The INDIA TODAY survey seeks to capture these distinctions by assessing institutions across 120+ attributes grouped under five parameters: Reputation & Governance; Academic & Research Excellence; Infrastructure & Living Experience; Personality & Leadership Development; and Career Progression & Placement. The weight for each parameter has been kept unchanged from past years to allow meaningful comparison over time.

Together, these measures are more useful than a placement figure or a publicity claim viewed in isolation. A university may advertise its highest salary package without disclosing how many students were placed, which programmes they came from or what the median outcome was. It may showcase